dia's premier pacer and his family were often seen travelling in different flights. Wife Sanjana Ganesan was working as a broadcaster during the tournament and chose to fly with their son in the commercial flights booked by her employers and not the Indian team's official flights. This meant that there were moments during the month-long tourney when regular passengers were asked to wait or make way for the Indian team at airports; on occasion, those passengers included the wife and child of the tournament's best-performing player.

It's these virtues, coupled with his exceptional performances that have led to talk of Bumrah being perfect to take on the job of next Test captain, even drawing comparisons with one of India's finest. "Bumrah and M.S. Dhoni are very similar, confident, calm and skillful," says Rayudu, who spent a lot of time playing under MSD. "All good captains have the ability to put themselves in other people's shoes, work with their limitations. That's the other thing he has in common with Dhoni. He'll make a good leader going forward."

For a country fed on a diet of batting superstars and their natural progression to leadership roles, Bumrah's emergence as the next plausible leader could mark a turning point in Indian cricket history. And even though his two Test matches as skipper (one win, one loss) don't provide enough of a sample size to pass a decisive verdict, comparisons with Dhoni only embellish his credentials. "He reminds me of MS," says Kaif, echoing Rayudu's sentiments. "Dhoni would hit the last ball for six, Bumrah bowls the last over. They both do high-pressure jobs, but also stay relaxed under pressure. These are all signs of a good captain."

It was Bumrah's 12 yorkers in a row in the Syed Mushtaq Ali tournament that first caught the attention of Wright and eventually led to the Ahmedabad youngster joining the Mumbai Indians. From those thunderbolts in first-class cricket to the yorker he bowled to dismiss England's Ollie Pope during the Vizag Test last season—"as gorgeous a yorker as any" is how the commentator on air described it—Bumrah has transitioned from potential great to certified legend. The only bowler in the history of the sport with a sub-20 average (19.40) after 40 tests, he now finds himself in a position where he can dare to aspire for the coveted tag of the greatest ever.

Meanwhile, as India gears up for another challenge with the ICC Champions Trophy this month, the entire country is sweating over Bumrah's fitness. Because with the current ICC player of the year in their ranks, reclaiming another global title wouldn't be asking for the moon. ■



photo courtesy@iSanjanaGanesan

WINNERS ALL Bumrah with wife Sanjana after the T20 World Cup final win in Barbados, Jun. 29, '24

BUMRAH'S AMAZING 2024

Wkts: Wickets; Avg: Average; SR: Strike Rate; Eco: Economy Rate
**At the T20I World Cup*

	TESTS	T20Is*
Matches	13	8
Wkts	71	15
Avg	14.9	8.2
SR	30.1	11.8
Eco	2.96	4.17

HOW HE COMPARES IN THE TOP 3

	JASPRIT BUMRAH	P.W. HASARANGA (SL)	TASKIN AHMED (BAN)
Matches	21#	30	30
Wkts	86	64	63
Avg	13.76	14.82	19.23
SR	26.97	14.25	24.14
Eco	3.06	6.24	4.78





Figures for Tests+ODIs+T20Is in 2024; # Bumrah did not play any ODIs in 2024